



# SHERPAS

THE NAME “SHERPA” COMES FROM THE TIBETAN WORDS for people (*shar*) and east (*wa*). The Sherpas are a distinct group of people who come from Tibet. There are 18 Sherpa

## PEOPLE OF THE EAST

### The high life

Sherpas are famous for guiding mountaineers up Mount Everest. Living at high altitudes between 8,500 and 14,000 ft (2,600 and 4,300 m), Sherpas are used to the mountainous terrain and thin air. Only certain animals and plants, such as yaks and potatoes, survive in this environment. Sherpas use them as much as possible, as everything else has to be brought in, even essentials like food and paper.

By law, no load should weigh more than 65 lb (30 kg).

#### A LOAD TO BEAR

Portering is a common occupation for men and women. Seventy percent of Nepal is so mountainous, it has no roads. All goods must be carried in, including cooking pots and oil.



#### POTATO HARVEST

Sherpa women and men have equal status. They share the work, from raising children to heavy farming. These women are hoeing potatoes, a staple food that is able to grow at high altitudes.



#### MORE THAN A PET

Looking after the yaks in the highlands is an important job. They provide almost everything the Sherpas need. Wool is turned into clothes, and leather into shoes. Dung is used as fuel and fertilizer. Yaks also transport heavy goods over long distances.



#### MAKING CHEESE

Yak's milk is an important commodity. It can be drunk in tea, or turned into butter or cheese. This boy is stirring cheese curds for his family. Cheese making is a growing industry, with cheese sold mainly to tourists.

